A Thin Veiled Night

The Hills Above Allentown

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INT. DANI'S KITCHEN - FRIDAY MORNING

DANI'S MOTHER stands at the kitchen table with Dani's backpack open. She picks up a small paperback-sized SPANISH BIBLE with a blue vinyl cover and a zipper around three sides like a pencil case, and opens the front cover.

"Daniela Peña Almonte" is written in ballpoint, pressed hard enough to show through on the back.

She zips the Bible into the front pocket of the backpack. Then she zips DANI PEÑA ALMONTE (12, seventh grade) into her coat up to the chin and pulls her braid out from under the collar. Dani has on flat black school shoes, and with the Bible inside, the backpack hangs a little heavier on the left.

CUT TO:

EXT. SOUTH MOUNTAIN MIDDLE SCHOOL / FRONT STEPS - AFTERNOON

The last bell rings, and kids pour onto Emaus Avenue. A CUSTODIAN is on the walk with a push broom, sweeping a busted bag of Takis into a dustpan while the wind picks up the red pieces and blows them down the steps.

ISAIAH WHITFIELD (13, eighth grade) already has his phone screwed onto a small bendy-leg tripod from his birthday, holding it out in front of him like a flashlight.

YADIEL ROSARIO (13, eighth, tallest by a head) wears his older brother's William Allen hoodie with the canary on the front, the sleeves hanging past his fingers.

Dani stands there with that backpack, her braid over her collar.

BRYCE KRESSLEY (11, sixth, small for his age) carries a cracked leather binocular case around his neck on a strap. The binoculars inside belong to his grandmother, who takes them to Hawk Mountain every fall to count hawks, and she only let him bring them today if he's home by dark.

ISAIAH
Everybody keeps posting the lights. White lights over South Mountain, real low, no sound. Two hundred comments under every video, and it's aliens, it's ghosts, it's the end of the world.

He turns the phone so they can see the comment threads under blurry white blobs.

ISAIAH (CONT'D)
It's drones. Or it's planes coming into the airport and the angle is weird. I'm going to get it clear, from close, and put it up, and that's the end of it.

YADIEL
From close how?

ISAIAH
From the pull-off. Right over top of where they come up.

YADIEL
My abuela says don't go up the mountain after dark.

ISAIAH
So we come down before dark.

DANI
Sunset is at six-thirty. We have three hours.

Bryce touches the binocular case to make sure it's still there.

BRYCE
Grandma said twice. Home by dark.

ISAIAH
Then we go now.

They start up Emaus while the custodian loses more Takis to the wind and keeps sweeping.

EXT. SIDE STREET CLIMBING SOUTH MOUNTAIN - CONTINUOUS

They pass the last houses, where the sidewalk ends under their feet and the patchy pavement gives out into a gravel shoulder and trees.

Behind a yellow sign saying the road isn't maintained in winter, a path starts up through the woods in a long zigzag worn down to dirt and roots by about a hundred years of kids.

EXT. SOUTH MOUNTAIN PATH - CONTINUOUS

It's warm for October, and they're sweating inside ten minutes. The oaks are just starting to turn brown, while the poplars have already dropped their leaves, which crunch and slide under their feet.

Isaiah talks most of the way up about how to shoot clear video, how to zoom in, and how a blurry clip can make people believe almost anything.

Dani's school shoes have no grip, and she slips onto one knee in the leaves. Yadiel reaches a hand back without turning, and she takes it so he can pull her up the steep part. Neither mentions it.

Halfway up, a single white roller skate with pink laces is lying on its back in the leaves beside the path, and all four wheels are missing. Bryce pokes it with his sneaker as he walks past, and that's all anyone does with it.

BRYCE
What if it isn't drones.

ISAIAH
Then it's planes.

BRYCE
What if it isn't planes.

Isaiah stops on the path and puts both hands on his knees to catch his breath.

ISAIAH
My mom says people see what they need to see. She says that's what church is. People needed a story, so they got one. She quit going when I was eight.

YADIEL
My abuela says your mom is going to come back.

ISAIAH
Your abuela says that about everybody.

YADIEL
She's been right about a lot of everybody.

Yadiel walks on up ahead, and that's the end of that.

EXT. SOUTH MOUNTAIN OVERLOOK - LATER

They come out of the trees onto the shoulder right above the pull-off a little after five, all four of them breathing hard with their faces red.

The pull-off is a wide gravel lot on the city side of the mountain with room for six cars and a steel guardrail at the edge. Nobody else is there, though fresh tire tracks curve through the gravel. Wind moves the sumac below the rail, with traffic way down below.

The sumac has turned deep red like a stop sign, running down into scrub oak and the backs of the first houses. To the left, the flat orange sun drops toward Trexlertown and throws long shadows from every steeple and smokestack across the roofs.

Downtown, the pale PPL Building stands above the rest with its top already lit. East along Hamilton, the streetlights come on one after another. The Lehigh River cuts a dark line through the middle, and to the right, past the hills, Bethlehem's old steel stacks glow in colored lights against the sky.

Down by the river a slow freight train rolls along, and at a crossing the horn gives two long pulls. The sound takes a second or two to climb the mountain to them.

Isaiah wraps the tripod legs around a guardrail post until the phone sits tight, then aims it over the sumac and hits record.

The rail feels cold under Dani's coat sleeve when she leans on it. Years back, someone painted J.R. + M.T. in silver on the post beside her, and most of the M has flaked off.

They wait.

Behind the far ridge the sun goes down, and the roofs turn from orange to blue as the streetlights start to matter.

Bryce keeps the binoculars up and calls what he spots.

BRYCE
Man walking a dog in a park. Bus.
Pigeon on a church.

Yadiel eats from a bag of chips he's saved since lunch and doesn't share them, until Dani looks at him and he shares them.

EXT. SOUTH MOUNTAIN OVERLOOK - DUSK

Twenty minutes to seven.

Past the rail the hillside drops fast through red sumac and crooked little oaks. Allentown is spread out below them,

its lights scattered across the dark like a jar tipped over on a table.

Below them, the first light comes up out of the sumac.

It rises out of the red bushes about a hundred feet down the slope and stops even with the scrub-oak tops, so the kids look down at it with the city lights behind it. That's the first thing wrong with it, because everyone talked about lights in the sky, and this one is below them.

The light is white and about the size of a basketball, and it doesn't blink.

A second light comes up beside it, then a third, and all three hang in a row in the dusk without a sound.

ISAIAH
Drones.

BRYCE
There's no buzz. There's no propellers. I can see the bushes right through the bottom of them. Isaiah, there's no anything holding them up.

Isaiah's phone keeps recording on the post, lighting his face white from the screen, and he doesn't reach for it.

All four phones light up together. Dani's buzzes in her coat, Yadiel's in his hoodie, and Bryce's goes off in his back pocket loud enough to make him jump.

Then Isaiah's phone speaker clicks on, and out comes the map lady's voice, calm and friendly and a little slow, the same tone she uses to say turn left in four hundred feet.

MAP LADY (ON PHONE)
Isaiah. You came to see us. Go ahead and ask.

Yadiel reaches out and grabs a fistful of the back of Isaiah's hoodie. Isaiah doesn't shake him off, standing at the rail with his mouth slightly open before he closes it and sets his jaw.

ISAIAH
How many cars on that train?

MAP LADY (ON PHONE)
Ninety-one.

ISAIAH
Bryce. Count it.

Bryce swings the binoculars to the river. His hands shake, so he braces his elbows on the rail and counts out loud under his breath. The train is long, the back half going behind buildings, and nobody moves.

He lowers the binoculars and doesn't say the number right away.

BRYCE
Ninety-one.

ISAIAH
What's my grandmother's middle name?

MAP LADY (ON PHONE)
Loretta.

Isaiah's hand closes tight on the guardrail top.

MAP LADY (ON PHONE) (CONT'D)
We were here before your city. We were here before the river had its name. We made the first of you, ages ago, and then we went away, and now we have come back for the ones who can see. You can see, Isaiah. The others are not ready. Step over the rail and come down, and we will show you where you came from. You can bring your camera.

The three lights drift a little closer uphill. Under them the sumac moves, red leaves flipping over to show pale undersides even though there's no wind on the kids' faces.

Isaiah puts a palm flat on the rail top, then brings his left knee up onto the steel.

YADIEL
Isaiah. No, bro. No.

ISAIAH
They answered. They answered everything. You heard them.

Isaiah swings a leg across. Past the rail there's only about two feet of loose gravel before the sumac drops away with nowhere solid to step. His sneaker hits the gravel and slides, and he grabs the rail to catch himself.

Yadiel keeps a fistful of the hoodie. Bryce lets the binoculars drop against his chest, grabs Isaiah's belt from behind with both hands, and sits down hard in the gravel with his heels dug in.

Dani unzips the front pocket of her backpack with her fingers stiff from the cold.

FLASHBACK TO:

INT. BEDROOM - SANTIAGO, DOMINICAN REPUBLIC - NIGHT (YEARS EARLIER)

Dani's mother sits on the edge of the bed while a fan runs in the window, and younger Dani listens from the pillow.

DANI'S MOTHER
If a voice comes to you and it is not right, ask it about Jesus. Ask it if He came in the flesh. If they are from God they will tell you yes. The others will not say it.

BACK TO:

EXT. SOUTH MOUNTAIN OVERLOOK - DUSK

Dani pulls out the small Spanish Bible and holds it shut against her coat with both hands.

DANI
Una pregunta.

Her voice comes out small, so she makes it louder.

DANI (CONT'D)
¿Jesucristo vino en carne? Sí o no.

Then she says it in English, slow and careful.

DANI (CONT'D)
I have one question. Jesus Christ came in the body. Yes or no?

Isaiah's phone stays silent on the post, with the little red record dot still blinking.

The three lights hang over the sumac, and the leaves under them stop moving. Down below, the train blows for another crossing, and the sound climbs the mountain and goes past them.

ISAIAH
Answer her.

He's still on the wrong side of the rail, one leg across, with Bryce's full weight pulling on the back of his belt.

ISAIAH (CONT'D)
You did the train. You did my grandma. Answer her. It's a yes or a no.

MAP LADY (ON PHONE)
Isaiah. Come down.

ISAIAH
Answer her question first.

MAP LADY (ON PHONE)
Come down, Isaiah. The others are not ready.

Isaiah stands there with the phone screen lighting his face, looking from the lights to the small blue Bible in Dani's hands and back again, the way he does when a science answer doesn't add up.

Then Isaiah swings his leg back over to the safe side. His knee bumps the tripod and spins it halfway around on the post, knocking Bryce backward into the gravel, and Isaiah plants his feet with both hands holding tight to the rail.

The lights come up the hill.

They rush up the hill together, tearing through sumac and scrub oak while the brush under them thrashes like a herd of deer bolting through.

Every phone buzzes and won't quit. From Isaiah's phone the map lady starts up again:

MAP LADY (ON PHONE)
Turn left. Turn left. Turn left.

It speeds up until the words run together.

Up close the lights are bigger and have lost their round shape, though none of the four will ever agree afterward on what shape they turned into.

Yadiel lets go of Isaiah's hoodie, steps up to the guardrail ahead of the other three, and speaks the way his abuela spoke in the kitchen when grease caught fire in the pan, loud and flat and sure.

YADIEL
En el nombre de Jesús. In the name of Jesus. Get off this mountain.

The lights stop about twenty feet down the slope, halting so hard it's like they ran into the guardrail, and they hang there shaking.

Then they drop.

All three lights drop into the sumac like stones into a pond and shoot out the bottom, skimming low over the rooftops, across Hamilton Street and the river, and out into the dark toward the airport until the four kids can't tell them from any other light.

Every phone shuts off at once.

The regular wind comes back up through the sumac, and down on the streets they hear the traffic again.

Bryce finds out his binoculars are gone. The strap snapped when he sat down hard, leaving only the empty leather case hanging from its own strap around his neck. He feels around in the gravel where he was sitting, and they aren't there, so he gets up on his knees and looks over the rail at the slope dropping into the dark red bushes.

BRYCE
Those are my grandma's. Those are for the hawks.

YADIEL
Nobody goes over that rail. Not tonight. Not for anything.

Bryce stays on his knees looking down into the dark, and then he stands up, brushes gravel off the seat of his jeans, and stays on this side of the rail.

EXT. SOUTH MOUNTAIN PATH - NIGHT

They walk down the path in the dark. Halfway down, Isaiah's phone comes back on with four percent left, and he turns on the flashlight and leads with his arm held out ahead. Nobody talks the whole way.

Dani carries the Bible in her hand the whole walk down and never puts it back in the pocket.

EXT. BOTTOM OF THE HILL / RESIDENTIAL STREET - NIGHT

At the bottom they come out onto a street with houses. On a porch a MAN stands on a stepladder working on Christmas lights along the gutter in mid-October, hanging them or taking last year's down, and he doesn't look down at them.

They walk past under him without stopping.

INT. ISAIAH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Isaiah sits on the floor with his back against the bed while his phone charges. Under the window the radiator ticks and knocks as it warms up for the first time this fall.

On the phone, every video from that evening is gone except one eleven-second clip.

He plays it.

On the screen, his knee has bumped the tripod and spun the phone halfway around on the post, so for those eleven seconds the camera points back at the four of them instead of out over the city.

Isaiah's leg comes back over the guardrail, Bryce falls backward in the gravel, Yadiel lets go of the hoodie to step up to the rail, and Dani in her coat holds the small blue Bible against her chest with both hands.

Behind Dani, standing on the pull-off gravel where no one had been, there's a TALL SHAPE that's taller than any grown man by a good deal. Its back is to the camera, and one hand rests on the guardrail beside her as it faces down the hill the same way she does.

Not one of the four saw it standing there.

Isaiah watches those eleven seconds over and over, and he doesn't post it, and never does.

The tall one never turns around.

Isaiah sits with the phone in both hands and watches the shape that won't turn.

INT. DANI'S KITCHEN - MONDAY MORNING

The radio on the counter gives the traffic on Route 22.

Dani's mother reaches for the blue Bible on the kitchen table to zip it into the backpack's front pocket like she did on Friday morning.

Before her mother can finish, Dani takes the Bible from her hands and slides it into her own coat pocket on the right, where she can reach it.

Her mother lets her, and from the doorway she watches Dani walk down the steps toward Emaus Avenue with one hand in that pocket and her thumb on the zipper.

FADE OUT.